

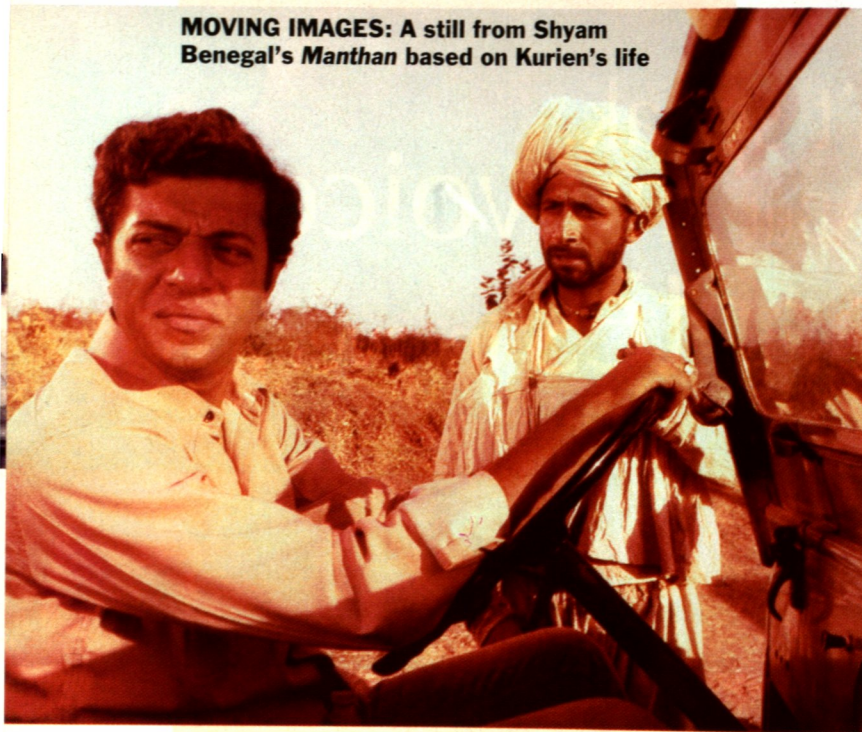
OPERATION FLOOD

Milk on the Boil

Kurien has always faced a conflict of interest between that of his farmer employees and the needs of poor urban consumers for the benefit of whom the projects were formulated—and his unquestionable dedication to farmers has often made things worse when dealing with urban bureaucrats. Kurien is undoubtedly a greater motivator of men than most. His priorities are questionable, the speed of implementation of his overall projects dismal, but in mobilising farmers into the cooperative fold, he

and explain how it will benefit and make farmers in India independent. We met several delegates to garner support for our proposal. Most of them resisted but two stood out: Australia and Pakistan. The lady heading the Australian delegation was initially opposed to our proposal because she was of the opinion that India would become dependent on aid. But on hearing us, she changed her stance. The Pakistani delegates, on the other hand, copied our proposal and presented it to FAO. But thankfully, our proposal had been cleared by then. In Rome, Patel was questioned how the project would function without the government's involvement. To which he replied that the government would give me five years for the project and in case it failed, they "would shoot me down."

MOVING IMAGES: A still from Shyam Benegal's *Manthan* based on Kurien's life



I give the credit of the project's success to radio as well, as it was on radio that I heard that European countries were throwing away huge quantities of excess milk and butter oil every year. I was working at Anand in the early 1960s and was preparing a self-sufficient and farmer-friendly cooperative dairy model. Asking these countries to give their excess to us then appeared a feasible way to fund our dairy scheme and that's how Operation Flood's funding model came into operation. Eventually, 176 AMULS (Anand Milk Union Limited) were replicated across the country to the benefit of farmers and consumers.

I have many fond memories associated with the three phases of the Operation Flood programme till it ended in 1992 and all through I was fortunate enough to have the unstinted support of almost all the prime ministers who stood by me and my project. Like when the then Union

minister Rao Birendra Singh questioned the basis of the programme and its implementation, Mrs Indira Gandhi came to my rescue and it was Singh who had to face the music. His opposition cost him his ministry. The success of the dairy model won me many unlikely admirers too. One of them was the RSS leader Guru Golwalkar who made me, a Christian and an atheist, a member of the cow protection committee. Thanks to these people, today the milk economy is worth Rs 2,00,000 crore and is the largest contributor to the country's agricultural GDP.

as told to Uday Mahurkar

has no equal. By October last year, 24 lakh farmers around the country had joined the Anand-pattern cooperatives, and had begun to control their own destiny. And it is for this massive mobilisation that Kurien will eventually be remembered. On his epitaph, will be his favourite boast, "Kurien was a servant of the farmer, not the government."

By Chander Uday Singh,
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The author is the father of the White Revolution and retired in 1998 as chairman of NDDB